rewarded for bad behavior—if Washington acceded, China's image in the US would only deteriorate.[201]

These US-India discussions on China followed a familiar path. Krishna Menon insisted that China wanted to improve relations with the US. Dulles retorted that there was scant evidence of this desire. He reminded the Indian envoy that after Bandung he had made an unconditional offer to negotiate with the Chinese.[202]

Indeed, the Indian intermediary efforts had an unintended impact—they partly resulted in Eisenhower and Dulles coming to see a Sino-US exchange of "commissioners" as a preferable option. They wanted to establish communications between China and the US without using third-party representatives. Dulles felt Krishna Menon had only "mix[ed] up the channels of communication" and "crossed wires," causing the situation to "slip … backwards."[203] US concern only intensified when different messages seemed to emanate from Beijing from the various channels being used; Washington was left not knowing whom to believe.[204] But the need to communicate persisted, given the "uneasy calm" in the Taiwan Strait and the possibility of Moscow otherwise insisting on China's inclusion in the four-power summit due to be held in July in Geneva. China's release of some American airmen created better conditions for a direct dialogue.[205] Besides, by July 1955, Dulles was "fed up with all the intermediaries."[206]

Dulles mentioned to Krishna Menon the possibility of direct Sino-US contact at a higher level in Geneva. The Indian envoy, who suggested Delhi and Moscow as alternate venues, responded that the outcome of such talks would depend on the subjects up for discussion.[207] Concerned that Krishna Menon would "warp" what the US was proposing in Geneva in his interactions with Chinese officials, Dulles asked Eisenhower to send a clarifying message to Nehru.[208]

Nehru was pessimistic about the Chinese reaction if the US kept the scope of the talks limited. He believed that Washington had not gone far enough and in fact wanted the Taiwan "question to remain unsettled and the tension to continue."[209] Acting on Nehru's concerns and British foreign secretary Harold Macmillan's advice, Dulles agreed to use less restrictive phrasing in the US proposal for talks.[210] Nehru wrote to Zhou recommending that China accept the US proposal to hold ambassadorial talks, noting his belief that American opinion had changed and "a realistic